

copy of your credit reports, go to www.annualcreditreport.com. To get all of your scores, try www.myfico.com. See section **Credit Reports And Credit Scores** for details.

- **Be wary of adjustable rate mortgages (ARMs). Make sure you know how high your interest rate could rise in the future—and how high your monthly payments could go. In most cases, it's best to get a fixed-rate mortgage instead. See chapter 7 for details.**
- **Before you go hunting for a home, get “prequalified” for a mortgage. Prequalification will not guarantee you a home loan, but it will give you an idea of how big a mortgage you can afford. It's also a good idea to get “preapproved.” This way, if you do find your dream home, you'll be absolutely sure you'll get a loan in time to buy it.**
- **If you've bought a home and you're having trouble making the payments, contact a free counseling service for help working out a repayment plan or possibly postponing payments until you get your finances in order. See section **If You're In Serious Debt** for details.**